

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 13

Medieval Halloween

Halloween Sleep Story for Adults

Soul Cakes and Bells

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the Pantheon in Rome to the last soul cakers, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books and museums, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

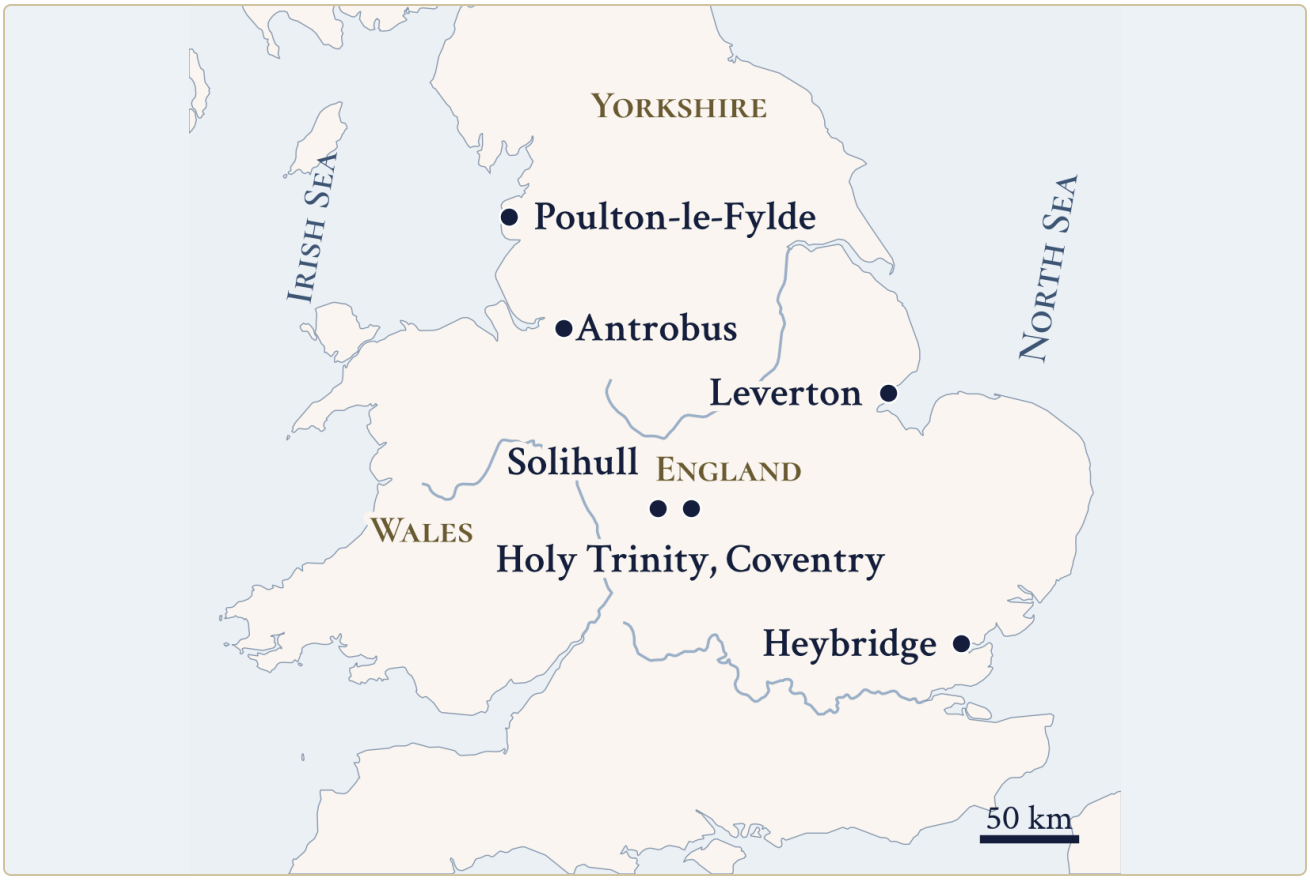
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Bells, bread and the souls

Let's begin in an English parish, as the bells are made ready.



Places plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). The episode's village is imagined and is not on the map.

AT A GLANCE

- 31 October to 2 November: All Hallows' Eve, All Saints and All Souls
- The bells were rung for the dead
- Bread was given in return for prayers

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Ten places from the episode, from Heybridge to Cluny.

Heybridge · In Essex, where in 1517 the parish paid for a new bell rope and frankincense before Hallowmass.

Leverton · In Lincolnshire, whose churchwardens paid for belfry work "agayns halomess" and paid the ringers on Allhallow night.

Holy Trinity, Coventry · Where in 1462 the deacons gathered money among the people for the ringers who rang for all Christian souls.

Bishop's Stortford · In Hertfordshire, which paid for a new bell wheel against All Hallowtide.

Poulton-le-Fylde · In Lancashire, near the Purgatory Field of the Teanlay fires.

Antrobus · In Cheshire, home of the soul cakers' play and its Wild Horse.

Solihull · Where John Collet's dole of 1565 was still given out on All Souls' Day in 1826.

Hodnet · In Shropshire, where Mrs Gill's soul-cake recipe was recorded.

Wittenberg · In Saxony, where Luther's theses of 31 October 1517 were written.

Cluny · The Burgundian abbey where Odilo ordered a day for all the faithful departed.

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A timeline of Hallowtide

From the Pantheon in Rome to the last soul cakers, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

835
1 November a holy day

1517
A new bell rope; Luther's theses

1546
"No watching nor ringing"

609/610 — Boniface IV dedicates the Pantheon in Rome to Mary and all martyrs, on 13 May.

731–741 — Gregory III dedicates a chapel in St Peter's to all saints, remembered on 1 November.

835 — Louis the Pious makes 1 November a holy day in the Frankish realm.

c. 998 — Odilo of Cluny orders the commemoration of all the faithful departed.

1200s — Rome takes up All Souls' Day.

1462 — Coventry's deacons gather money for the ringers on All Hallows' night.

1511 — The Festyvall is printed: "bake brade and dele it for all crysten soules."

1517 — Heybridge buys a new bell rope; Luther writes his theses on 31 October.

1546 — Henry VIII abolishes the vigil: "no watching nor ringing."

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A timeline of Hallowtide

The story goes on from here, slowly.



1547	The Chantries Act closes the chantries.
1556	Under Mary, Leverton pays its ringers on Allhallow night.
1559	Elizabeth's injunctions forbid ringing for the dead after Evening Prayer.
1573	Thomas Tusser: have your wheat sown before Hallowmas Eve.
1590s	Shakespeare's Speed speaks "like a beggar at Hallowmas".
1678	Soul-mass cakes recorded in Lancashire and Herefordshire.
1826	John Collet's 1565 dole is still given at Solihull.
1883–1886	Charlotte Burne's Shropshire Folk-Lore records soul-cake rhymes and recipes.

Some early dates are traditional or approximate. No medieval soul-cake recipe survives.

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THE NIGHT OF THE SOULS ACROSS EUROPE

Bread for the souls

Now let's look further, at bread for the souls across Europe.



Customs of the first days of November named in the episode, on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Names are for orientation, not borders.

People you'll meet

The popes, kings and writers you'll meet along the way.

Boniface IV · Pope who dedicated the Pantheon to Mary and all martyrs.

Gregory III & Gregory IV · Popes who fixed and spread the feast of all saints on 1 November.

Louis the Pious · Frankish emperor who made 1 November a holy day in 835.

Odilo of Cluny · Abbot who ordered the commemoration of all the faithful departed.

Martin Luther · Monk of Wittenberg who wrote to Albrecht of Mainz on 31 October 1517.

Frederick the Wise · Elector whose relics at the All Saints' Church drew pilgrims on All Saints.

Thomas Cranmer · Archbishop who wrote to Henry VIII about the ringing on All Hallow night.

Henry VIII · King who abolished the vigil and its ringing in 1546.

Elizabeth I · Queen whose injunctions ended ringing for the dead.

Thomas Tusser · Farming poet of Five Hundred Points of Good Husbandry.

John Aubrey · Antiquary who wrote down the soul-cake customs of his day.

Charlotte Burne · Folklorist who gathered Shropshire's soul-cake rhymes and recipes.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The new bell rope at Heybridge in 1517
- The deacons of Coventry gathering money for the ringers
- “Bake brade and dele it for all crysten soules”
- The Wild Horse of the Antrobus soul cakers
- Children with cloth bags for Pão-por-Deus in Portugal

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

No medieval recipe for a soul cake survives: the recipes we have are from later centuries. The cross on top is not a documented medieval rule, so the episode treats it as one family’s choice. Whether Luther nailed his theses to a door is still debated; the letter of 31 October 1517 is certain. The village, Agnes, Wat and Hugh are imagined; the customs, places and parish payments are real.





Artistic impressions of souling at a door and of a basket of soul cakes, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

The Stripping of the Altars: Traditional Religion in England, 1400–1580 ↗, Eamon Duffy (Yale University Press, 2nd ed., 2005).

The Stations of the Sun: A History of the Ritual Year in Britain ↗, Ronald Hutton (Oxford University Press).

Halloween: From Pagan Ritual to Party Night ↗, Nicholas Rogers (Oxford University Press, 2003).

Trick or Treat: A History of Halloween ↗, Lisa Morton (Reaktion Books, 2012).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Victoria and Albert Museum, London: medieval and Renaissance church art.

British Museum, London: medieval Europe galleries.

In your own parish: many old churches still have medieval bells in the tower, some with Latin saints' names cast on them.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you baked a soul cake tonight, would you mark it with a cross, or leave it plain?

"Somewhere a bell is ringing for the souls, slowly, and the bread is cooling by the fire."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

Watch the episode: youtube.com/watch?v=Xu7BU5ZFYcI

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